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TAKE TEN

Here's our list of what we think are the best cross-platform games ever

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If you're reading this magazine, you've probably played video games at least once in your life, be it on those old Sega controllers or on today's mean consoles. Over the years, games have evolved from the simple but highly addictive *Dave* to *Contra* and on to today's near-realistic-physics-and-animation games and massively multiplayer online (MMO) games like *Gears Of War*.

Users of platforms other than Windows have always felt like second-class citizens when it comes to gaming. Hardware and software issues forced gamers to stick to Windows when they wanted their dose of guns, cars and the occasional babe. Graphic cards had drivers only for Windows, and lesser users were stuck with poor graphics. Even if you didn't mind playing without the eye-candy on, most games required DirectX 8 or higher.

It's better now, though. Both NVIDIA and ATI have released Linux drivers for the GeForce 8800 and Radeon series cards respectively. Game devel-

opers have started using OpenGL, an open source 3D graphics API, which is compatible across most platforms. More graphics cards are now compatible with OpenGL.

All this has contributed to increased attention to gaming on non-Windows platforms. Many developers have opened up the source code for commercial games (*Quake 3* is a good example). Linux ports of commercial games like *Quake 3*, *Doom*, *Neverwinter Nights*, and *Unreal Tournament* have been released by the developers, while third-party companies have ported many Windows games to Linux. In addition, some open source projects have aimed at remaking classic proprietary games into open source or free versions (such as *FreeCiv*, a remake of *Civilization II*, while *OpenTTD* is inspired by *Transport Tycoon Deluxe*).

Here, we've picked 10 games from diverse genres: FPS, RTS, Simulation, Racing, RPG. Some are free, some are paid. All of them run on at least Windows and Linux. May the strategising, shooting, and non-blinking of eyes begin—but remember to eat and sleep!

Sauerbraten

<http://www.sauerbraten.org>

A FPS deathmatch game based on the very popular *Cube*, *Sauerbraten* is strictly for the trigger-happy: shoot, duck, and then shoot some more! It's a free and open source.

Frankly, the game has no storyline. You are plonked into the middle of a map: choose from Jungle, Factory, Shade, and many other options. Grab those guns, ammo packs, and rocket launchers lying around—and start shooting at critters that swarm from all around. Your enemies look like they



Gotta blast somebody off with the rocket!

came straight out the dreams of a darkly disturbed teenager—misshapen trolls and human-headed tyrannosaurs who go by names like Slith and Rattamata. Depending on the skill level, the gameplay becomes more fast and furious.

The AI is dumb: your enemies will be drawn to you like moths to a flame, and they sell their lives cheap without even sidestepping your shots. Stand still and you are apt to be slaughtered. Use cover wisely—some environments provide ample cover while others are virtually empty spaces.

For the masochistic: monsters keep kicking your body after you've died—bug or feature?

Fans of the FPS deathmatch genre will find *Sauerbraten* right up their alley. The game can be played in single-player, multiplayer, and online modes with either human players or bots.

Rating: 6.5/10